

TYPING WITH YOUR THOUGHTS

If you've always wanted to control a computer with your mind, your time has come. The Wadsworth Centre in Albany, New York has come up with a brain-computer interface that allows you to type with your thoughts. It uses a helmet with electrodes connected to your head. More here: <http://dgit.in/wvTypeThought>

THE SPREADSHEET WAY

Spreadsheet software (think Microsoft

Excel) have become ubiquitous in the business world, but the concept actually goes back more than 3 decades, starting with VisiCalc. Read noted journalist Steven Levy's nostalgic take on spreadsheets here: <http://dgit.in/wvSpreadsheet>

GOING VIRAL

Ever wondered How and why does a piece of

media go viral, and is there a science behind it? A conference at MIT entitled "What Makes The Internet Awesome?" attempts to answer this question. Read more to know if you can also do something to go viral online. <http://dgit.in/wvViral>

RECREATING THE HUMAN HEART

Doctors Bud Frazier and Billy Cohn may have cracked

the code to creating an artificial heart. Their creation, a 10,000rpm, non-beating artificial heart might be the best emulation of a human heart yet. <http://dgit.in/wvArtificialHeart>

How offline retailers can make a comeback

Growth of e-commerce websites does not mean dead end for the traditional brick and mortar retailers.

– By Kul Bhushan

Google recently published a detailed study on the massive growth of e-retail industry in India. The study said the online commerce will become a whopping \$15 billion market by 2016. While e-commerce is evidently growing, traditional brick and mortar retailers and wholesalers have taken a huge hit. Apparently, retailers are finding it tough to compete with the heavy discounts offered by the online stores.

Despite multiple challenges, offline retailers shouldn't give up hopes on competing with the e-commerce websites. However, they need to innovate, expand and most importantly go aggressive on areas where online retailers are still struggling. Offline retailers already have the infrastructure for ensuring enough stock and advantage of face to face interactions. While they can continue to focus on these areas, here are some suggestions on how they can beat or at least compete with online retailers:

Contrary to the notion, offline retailer can very well take advantage of the ongoing online boom. One of the options that's being widely considered is Omni-channel Retailing under which they can provide seamless customer experience via multiple channels, and target today's well educated and informed consumers.

One of the dimensions of Omni-channel Retailing is a deeper integration between web and store so that when a customer buys anything online he gets customer support

at a store, and vice versa. Under the Device2Web model, customers can access the web store through various Internet-connected touch points such as mobile phones, kiosks, tablets etc.

"They (offline retailers) need to adopt Omni-channel Retailing, where they integrate these touch points to provide shoppers a 'buy anytime, anywhere' experience. For example: Shoppers can try products in store and buy online, buy from a store and place a return/exchange request online," says Mr Mehul Jobanputra, CEO and Cofounder of DesiDime.com.

Improved customer service:

As per the Google study, a lot of online shoppers aren't satisfied. A lot of customers have complained about the complicated return process. About 67% said that the return process is too complicated and expensive. Trust is another major issue for non-buyers as 55% of them don't trust the quality of the product online, says the Google study. Slow internet has also been pointed out as a major hurdle for online shoppers.

A recent study on India's E-Tailing Industry – Seller's Perspective 2014 done by Spire Research and Consulting also said that lack of robust payment mechanisms; Cash On Delivery (COD) options were prone



to risks as well as payment delays. Also, difficulties in logistics and order placements were some of the key obstructions faced by sellers/respondents in the e-tailing space. The studies clearly state that customers are very unsatisfied with the services part offered by e-commerce stores.

Competitive discounts, Cheaper extended warranties:

Offline retailers should also consider giving deeper discounts and cheaper extended warranties along with a personalised shopping experience. In our brands versus e-commerce analysis, we had pointed it out brands are reluctant to let their products sell through sites such as Flipkart and Snapdeal.

Offline retailers need to play on the personal touch. They need to ensure their staff are highly trained and are able to guide customers to what they want to buy. Online shopping while convenient is impersonal. Read the full article here: <http://dgit.in/OComeBack>